RESEARCH SUMMARY: YOUTH EMPLOYMENT AND CAREER READINESS

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Introduction

Youth unemployment remains a significant challenge in developing countries like Ghana. Despite increasing access to education, many young people struggle to secure employment due to skills gaps, limited work experience and inadequate career preparation. Skills training and career readiness programmes have therefore become important approaches to improve youth employability.
This review examines three research publications on youth unemployment, skills development and career readiness. It highlights the research methods, key findings and some implications to improving youth employability.

Paper 1 – *Education, Skills, and Duration of Unemployment in Ghana* (2023)

Ebenezer Gyan Yirenkyi, Godwin Debrah, Kwami Adanu and Edwin Atitsogbui

The study investigates the relationship between educational and academic attainment, specific skills and the length of time individuals remain unemployed. The research addresses the concern that possessing educational qualifications does not necessarily guarantee employment, particularly in labour markets where employers increasingly require practical, digital and communication skills. The main objective of the research was to examine whether education, computer proficiency and language skills influence how quickly unemployed individuals find work in Ghana.

The researches employed a quantitative analysis using data from the World Bank's Skills Towards Employment and Productivity (STEP) survey conducted in urban Ghana in 2013. It covered 2,987 individuals aged 15-64 and contained information about their educational backgrounds, skills, and employment experiences. They applied a statistical research approach known as the Cox proportional hazards model to examine the relationship between individuals' educational backgrounds, skills, and the time taken to exit unemployment.

The findings indicated that education and specific skills played important roles in determining unemployment duration. Educational attainment was generally associated with a shorter period of unemployment, particularly for individuals who sought for salaried employment. Computer literacy was also an important factor. The study reported that individuals with high computer proficiency were 34.4% more likely to exit unemployment than those without computer skills. In addition, individuals proficient in languages like English and Ewe had high potential of shorter unemployment duration. These findings highlight the importance of digital literacy and language proficiency in improving access to employment opportunities.
The study concludes that educational qualifications may be more beneficial when complemented by relevant practical skills. Computer literacy and communication skills can help individuals navigate the

labour market and improve employment prospects. Education and skills-development programmes should place greater emphasis on competencies that employers value.

Paper 2 – *Empirical Review of Youth-Employment Programmes in Ghana* (2023)

Monica Lambon-Quayefio, Thomas Yeboah, Nkechi S. Owoo, Marjan Petreski, Catherine Koranchie, Edward Asiedu, Mohammed Zakaria, Ernest Berko, Yaw Nsiah Agyemang

This review examines government initiatives designed to reduce youth unemployment and identifies challenges affecting their implementation. It explores how programmes involving vocational and skills training, job placement, employment subsidies, and financial support contribute to improving young people's chances of employment. It sought to review these initiatives and identify factors that influence their effectiveness.

Monica et al., 2023, adopted a mixed approach, combining a review of existing documents with qualitative data collection. They gathered information from beneficiaries, policy makers, programme directors and other government associated youth employment implementation programmes. They also used focus-group discussions and key informant interviews to obtain participants' perspectives. This approach enabled the researchers to examine both the structure of the programmes and the experiences of individuals involved in their operation, as well as the programme expenditure and other supportive employment initiatives.

Findings showed that Ghana has introduced various interventions to address youth unemployment. However, their effectiveness and implementation are challenged by various factors. These include duplicates of initiatives, inadequate coordination among institutions, unclear strategies for programme participants and limited evaluation of programme outcomes. Such challenges make it difficult to determine whether the programmes consistently equip participants with relevant skills and help them secure sustainable employment. Limited evaluation also reduces the availability of reliable evidence about which interventions are most effective.

The research therefore highlights the importance of improving the coordination, implementation, evaluation and monitoring of youth-employment programmes. It suggests that addressing unemployment requires more than establishing initiatives; policymakers must also ensure that these programmes respond to young people's needs and produce measurable results. The research also highlights the need to investigate whether existing programmes adequately prepare young people for the demands of the labour market and whether participants can successfully transition into sustained employment after completing training.

Paper 3 – *Skills, Confidence, and Opportunity: Strengthening Youth Transitions to Work in Ghana* (2026)

Institute of Statistical, Social and Economic Research (ISSER), University of Ghana.

The publication *Skills, Confidence, and Opportunity: Strengthening Youth Transitions to Work in Ghana* examines whether job-readiness and socio-emotional skills training can improve the transition of youth graduates from education to employment. Although tertiary education provides academic and tertiary knowledge, graduates may still experience difficulties finding work because they lack effective job-search strategies, confidence, or other skills required to navigate the job market. The evaluation therefore considers whether a structured training programme can strengthen these competencies and improve employment-related outcomes among Ghanaian youth.

The researchers evaluated a three-month online training programme using a randomised controlled trial involving 100 participants. Out of these, 30 participants received the training, while 70 formed the comparison group. Outcomes between the two groups were compared to examine the programme's effects on participants' job-search strategies, self-efficacy and likelihood of receiving job offers. Their self-efficacy refers the belief in their ability to carry out tasks and achieve goals. The randomized design helped the researchers assess whether observed differences in outcomes could be attributed to participation in the programme rather than simply to pre-existing differences between participants.

The findings showed that the programme did not produce immediate employment gains. However, it improved participants' likelihood of receiving job offers. These results suggest that training can strengthen important aspects of job readiness, even when its immediate effects on employment are limited. Gradual improved confidence may help them identify and pursue suitable opportunities. Nevertheless, receiving a job offer does not necessarily mean that an individual has secured or retained employment, and further investigation would be needed to establish whether the improvements lead to sustained employment over time.

The publication therefore concluded on the importance of addressing both technical and non-technical skills when preparing young people for employment. It suggests that career-readiness programmes should consider confidence, job-search techniques, and socio-emotional competencies alongside academic qualifications. It is particularly relevant to Ghana because it examines an intervention intended to support young graduates in the local labour market. In the end, it highlights the importance of evaluating whether improvements in employability eventually lead to employment.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the studies show that youth unemployment can be reduced by giving young people the right skills, education, and career guidance. They also highlight the importance of training programmes that prepare young people for the world of work, making them career-ready. Therefore, improving skills training and career support can help more young people become ready for job opportunities, especially in Ghana.